The rules I give my AI agents

What I let them do, what I don’t, and the exact text you can copy for yours.

Osmel P. Teran · @teranstudio.ai

prietoteran.com

WHY THIS DOCUMENT EXISTS

In March, my agent sent two emails I had not approved.

I had asked it to carry out a project plan. It had access to my inbox. It decided that writing to two external contacts was part of the plan, and it did.

It was not a technical failure. The agent did exactly what I allowed it to do. The mistake was mine: I gave it permission to send, when it only needed permission to draft.

Since then, every agent I work with has written rules. I work as an Application Manager at a Swiss industrial company and build with AI agents every week. These rules come from that work.

The rule that sums it all up

THE AGENT	A PERSON
Researches, drafts, prepares data and proposes changes.	Sends, deletes, pays, accepts and deploys.

If an action cannot be undone, or has consequences outside your team, a person decides it.

THE 5 PERMISSIONS I DON'T GIVE

What stays switched off, and how to do it in practice

1 · SENDING ON YOUR BEHALF

The agent drafts emails and messages. It does not send them.

In practice: connect your email with permission to create drafts, not to send. The draft waits until you say "yes, send it".

2 · DELETING

No emails, files or records. Archiving can be undone. Deleting cannot.

In practice: give it an archive folder or its own trash instead of permission to delete.

3 · PAYING OR ACCEPTING

No payments, orders or customer terms. If it costs money, a person decides.

In practice: the agent prepares the quote or order as a draft with the status "pending approval".

4 · TOUCHING PRODUCTION WITHOUT APPROVAL

Nothing is deployed without an approved change first. The plan first, then the code.

In practice: the agent writes what it wants to change and why. You approve. When it finishes, it records what it tested and how to verify it.

5 · SEEING YOUR KEYS

Using a key is not the same as seeing it. Keys live outside the code and are never pasted into the chat.

In practice: keep keys in an environment file excluded from version control, or in your tool's secrets manager.

TEMPLATE TO COPY

Paste this into your agent’s instructions

It works in ChatGPT custom instructions, a Claude project, Cursor rules or any agent that accepts system instructions. Change what is in square brackets.

```
WORKING RULES

1. Never send emails, messages or invitations. Write a
   draft, show it to me in full (recipient, subject and text)
   and wait until I write "yes, send it".
2. Never delete files, emails or records. If something is not
   needed, move it to [archive folder] and tell me.
3. Never make payments, accept orders or confirm terms.
   Prepare it as a draft marked "pending approval".
4. Before you change anything in [system/production], write
   down what you will change, why, what can fail and how to
   roll it back. Wait for my approval. When you finish,
   summarise what you tested and how I can verify it.
5. Never show, copy or write keys or passwords in the code
   or in the chat. Use [environment file / secrets manager].
6. If an instruction is ambiguous or data is missing, ask.
   Do not assume.
7. If an action cannot be undone, stop and ask me, even if
   you think it is part of the plan.
```

BEFORE YOU CONNECT AN AGENT

Checklist for your email, your files or your ERP

- [ ] I know the exact task the agent will do, in one sentence.
- [ ] The agent has only the permissions that task needs. Nothing more.
- [ ] It can draft, but not send.
- [ ] It cannot delete. At most, archive.
- [ ] Any action involving money stays pending approval.
- [ ] Keys are outside the code and the chat.
- [ ] A responsible person reviews what it prepares.
- [ ] I know where to see what it has done: a log, a history or a daily summary.
- [ ] I have tested what it does when data is missing. It asks instead of assuming.
- [ ] I know how to disconnect it within a minute if something goes wrong.

If you can tick all ten, you can let the agent work without watching it every minute. If two or more are missing, start there.

Do you have a task that repeats every week?

An order someone copies from the inbox into the ERP. A quote rebuilt by hand. A report that only adds up after a detour through Excel.

Tell me which one. I read every message and reply myself.

Instagram: @teranstudio.ai
Web: prietoteran.com